

The Instability Itself Is the Institution: Ministerial Survival and Institutional Learning in Peru, 1821–2026

Jose Manuel Magallanes Reyes

Departamento de Ciencias Sociales e Instituto PULSO
Pontificia Universidad Católica del Perú

Abstract

Why do political systems that change so much change so little in how they govern? This paper addresses that question through an original dataset of 1,062 ministerial spells covering five portfolios in Peru from 1821 to 2026. Rather than treating ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained, we treat it as a signal: an observable trace of the continuity conditions under which governing experience either accumulates into institutional knowledge or is repeatedly lost. We organize the analysis around two analytical heuristics. The first is the institutional epoch — the path-dependent period between critical junctures — which captures whether successive historical ruptures produced durable improvements in continuity conditions. The second is the protective belt — a localized architecture of external accountability relationships that, where it exists, insulates certain ministries from the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. Kaplan–Meier survival curves, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional hazards models show that epochs explain ministerial survival far better than individual traits or portfolio membership, and that continuity conditions did not improve monotonically across two centuries. The largest shift in the data occurred between the Oligarchic State and the Power-Sharing epoch; the most recent democratic period represents a partial regression toward the founding pattern of chronic interruption. The protective belt emerges only after 1993, when external accountability structures raised the cost of Economy minister replacement beyond what domestic political pressure alone could sustain. The central theoretical finding is that chronic ministerial instability in Peru is not evidence of absent institutions but of a durable informal one: the escape valve through which political pressure is absorbed without producing structural change. The instability itself is the institution.

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“Se vogliamo che tutto rimanga
com’è, bisogna che tutto cambi.”

Il Gattopardo
Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa,
1958

Introduction

Governing is hard. Education, health, public safety, and economic development are not technical problems with known solutions, but complex social challenges that demand sustained institutional effort. Good policy takes time to design, time to implement, and even longer to produce visible social outcomes. Good practices diffuse gradually. Organizations accumulate knowledge slowly. Institutional learning emerges only when that accumulated knowledge is preserved, transmitted, and refined across successive administrations. Citizens experience meaningful change only after years of coherent action in the same direction. In the long run, successful governance depends less on isolated political decisions than on the organizational conditions that allow knowledge to persist beyond individual officeholders.

After more than two hundred years of republican life, the Peruvian political class has repeatedly changed governments, cabinets, constitutions, and political coalitions. Yet the underlying pattern remains remarkably stable. Each new administration appoints a cabinet whose members understand, implicitly or explicitly, the terms of their engagement: they are expected to manage complexity on behalf of the president, but they may also be sacrificed whenever political pressure demands a visible response. Their departure rarely resolves the conflict that triggered it. The resignation of a premier or any other minister may relieve immediate pressure, but it seldom addresses the underlying causes of crisis. Cabinet reshuffles therefore signal political responsiveness without necessarily producing institutional correction.

This persistence should not be mistaken for an absence of adaptation. Political actors continuously learn how to navigate constitutional ambiguities, manage public blame, and deploy ministerial replacement as a mechanism for absorbing political pressure. If the political class has accumulated any expertise, it has largely been in reproducing established responses to crisis rather than transforming the institutional conditions that generate those crises. Governments change. Ministers change. Yet the repertoire through which instability is managed remains remarkably stable. This cycle has characterized much of Peru's republican history.

Political scientists often describe this type of persistence through the concept of path dependence, whereby accumulated institutional choices progressively constrain subsequent alternatives. Yet paths do break. Roman Krznaric (2024) argues that transformative institutional change requires what he calls a *disruption nexus*: a major crisis, social movements capable of amplifying that crisis, and a compelling institutional idea ready to occupy the political space created by disruption. France's Fifth Republic illustrates this dynamic. The Algerian War provided the crisis, Gaullism supplied the political movement, and constitutional redesign centered on a strong executive offered the institutional solution. The resulting transformation was not the product of a single event but the culmination of decades of unresolved executive instability. More importantly, it fundamentally altered the conditions under which political continuity was produced. The legacy of the Fifth Republic was therefore not merely institutional reform, but a durable change in the patterns of executive stability that had characterized French politics for more than a century.

Prior to the Fifth Republic, France exhibited levels of executive instability comparable to those observed throughout much of Peru's republican history. Figure 1 illustrates this similarity. Peru reached twenty-three premier appointments during the 1890s, while France reached twenty during the 1930s. After 1958, however, the trajectories diverged sharply. French premier appointments declined to a stable range of three to six per decade and have remained there ever since, whereas Peru has gradually returned to levels characteristic of the nineteenth century. Peru has experienced no shortage of potential disruption nexuses—or, as they will later be conceptualized in this paper, critical junctures: independence without effective state-building, the War of the Pacific, hyperinflation, political violence, the collapse of the

Fujimori regime, and the prolonged constitutional crisis beginning in 2016. Each represented a historical moment in which alternative institutional trajectories became plausible.

The central question, however, is not whether institutional change occurred. Peru's republican history is full of constitutional reforms, regime transitions, and political ruptures. The more fundamental question is whether these transformations altered the organizational conditions under which knowledge could be preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time. From this perspective, a critical juncture matters not simply because it generates new institutional arrangements, but because it may establish a durable political framework capable of reshaping the conditions under which organizations accumulate knowledge and governments learn. France appears to have experienced such a transformation after 1958. Peru's trajectory raises the possibility that institutional innovation and organizational learning do not necessarily coincide.

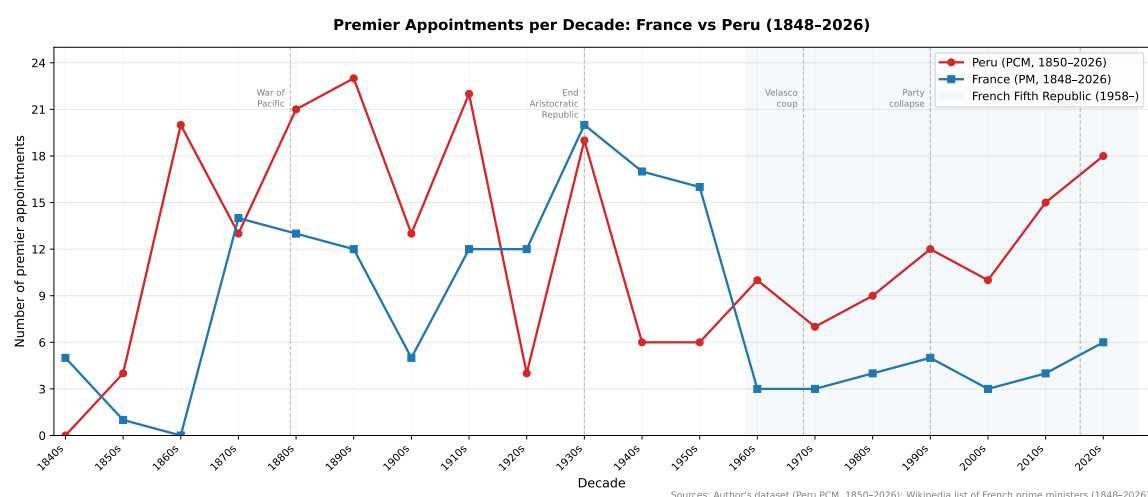


Figure 1

Premier Appointments per Decade: France vs. Peru, 1848–2026.

Sources: Author's dataset (based on Gálvez Montero and García Vega (2016a, 2016b)); Wikipedia list of French prime ministers (1848–2026).

This paper approaches that question through ministerial continuity. Ministerial duration is not interpreted as evidence of organizational learning itself. Rather, it constitutes observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge may accumulate. Organizations do not preserve knowledge because particular individuals remain indefinitely in office. Instead, sustained continuity creates opportunities for organizational routines, institutional memory, policy procedures, and accumulated expertise to be retained and transmitted despite inevitable personnel turnover. Ministerial continuity therefore represents a necessary—although not sufficient—condition for organizational knowledge accumulation.

Political science has traditionally examined these issues through separate research traditions. Ministerial duration has been analyzed using survival and event-history methods, whereas long-term institutional development has largely been studied through the comparative-historical literature on path dependence and critical junctures. This paper connects these traditions by reconceptualizing ministerial continuity as an observable indicator of the organizational conditions required for knowledge accumulation and institutional learning.

The empirical strategy follows two complementary heuristics derived from the theoretical framework developed below. The first examines variation in ministerial continuity across historically distinct political frameworks in order to evaluate how opportunities for organizational knowledge accumulation changed over time. The second compares continuity across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework, recognizing that some organizations may become partially insulated from the broader political dynamics affecting the cabinet as a whole. Together, these perspectives distinguish historical variation from organizational variation in the conditions under which organizational knowledge may accumulate.

The question guiding this study is straightforward: *Have Peru's successive political frameworks generated different opportunities for the accumulation of organizational knowledge?*

This question cannot be answered directly because organizational knowledge is not directly observable in historical records. Instead, the analysis evaluates the necessary organizational condition under which knowledge may accumulate: continuity. If organizational continuity constitutes a prerequisite for knowledge accumulation, then systematic differences in ministerial continuity should reveal systematic differences in the opportunities available for organizations to preserve, accumulate, and transmit knowledge over time.

The theoretical framework translates this general question into three empirical questions. *First*, what continuity conditions characterized Peru's successive political frameworks? *Second*, did those continuity conditions differ systematically across political frameworks? *Third*, within the same political framework, did some ministerial portfolios systematically exhibit greater continuity than others?

To answer these questions, we construct an original dataset of individual ministerial spells covering the period from 1821 to 2026. The analysis focuses on five portfolios that capture distinct organizational functions within the executive branch. The Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM) represents the political center responsible for coordinating cabinet action and maintaining executive cohesion. The Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) represents the technocratic center responsible for fiscal and macroeconomic policy. The Ministries of Interior, Health, and Education represent policy sectors confronting some of Peru's most persistent governance challenges according to official yearly surveys (INEI, 2024). Ministerial spells are subsequently organized into historically distinct political frameworks derived from Peru's critical junctures (Lopez Jimenez et al., 2025). Combining descriptive analyses

with survival models, the study evaluates how organizational continuity varied across political frameworks and ministerial portfolios, thereby providing empirical evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation becomes possible.

1 Literature Review

The political science literature on ministerial survival has converged around two broad families of explanations. The first explains variation in ministerial tenure through characteristics of ministers themselves. The second emphasizes the political and institutional environments within which ministers operate. Table 1 summarizes the principal covariates identified across the core studies.

Table 1

Trait-based and Context-based Predictors of Ministerial Survival

Author(s)	Trait-based	Context-based
Blondel (1988)	Career duration; parliamentary vs. managerial profile	Party system norms; head-of-government style; country context
Huber & Martinez-Gallardo (2008)	Ideological distance from government center; PM party membership; portfolio importance	Coalition type; minority government; electoral volatility; party fractionalization
Dewan & Dowding (2005)	Resignation issue salience; ministerial seniority	PM support level; media attention; single-party vs. coalition system
Fischer et al. (2012)	Age; education; gender; portfolio rank	PM popularity; regime type; frequency of resignation calls
Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán (2015)	Portfolio type; technocrat/partisan/outsider profile; first cabinet appointment	Protests; scandals; electoral calendar; term limits; reelection rules
Camerlo & Castaldo (2024)	Partisan rank within party hierarchy (leader, high-rank, low-rank, newcomer, shadow, defector)	Party government model applicability; regime type; party institutionalization level
Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian (2023)	Technical expertise; presidential group membership; prior electoral experience (<i>risk factor</i>)	Economic growth; GDP per capita; legislative powers; regime type; portfolio area
Mejía et al. (2021)	Education; gender; regional origin; prior elected office	Coalition type; legislative majority; party-system change
Alexiadou & Gunaydin (2019)	Technocratic profile; non-partisan status; reform commitment	Economic crisis severity; electoral system type; party control of portfolio
Baturo & Elkins (2014)	Personal traits as time-invariant officeholder effects (education, prior career)	Regime institutionalization; personalization vs. office-based authority
Jara Iñiguez & Cedeño Alcívar (2019)	Managerial performance lifecycle (inverted-U over tenure)	Presidential appointment and dismissal capacity; political trust as selection criterion

1.1 Trait-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Trait-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the officeholder. Across different institutional settings, scholars have shown that ministers' professional backgrounds, political careers, partisan affiliations, and personal resources influence their probability of remaining in office. Early studies emphasized broad distinctions between managerial and parliamentary profiles, as well as the effects of career trajectories and prior political experience (Blondel, 1988). Subsequent

work expanded the range of relevant characteristics to include age, education, gender, portfolio rank, and seniority within government (Dewan & Dowding, 2005; Fischer et al., 2012).

More recent research has refined these categories by focusing on the organizational and political resources that ministers bring to office. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that technical expertise and membership in presidential networks increase ministerial survival, while prior electoral experience may paradoxically operate as a risk factor (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Across four Latin American countries between 1945 and 2020, career politicians proved more vulnerable to dismissal than technocrats. The finding suggests that ministerial value cannot be reduced to political experience alone; survival depends on the type of resources political leaders seek to preserve.

The literature has also moved beyond simple dichotomies between partisan and non-partisan ministers. Camerlo and Castaldo argue that partisan affiliation conceals substantial variation in the strength of a minister's relationship with the party organization. Their framework distinguishes among leaders, high-ranks, low-ranks, newcomers, shadows, and defectors according to levels of engagement, consolidation, and hierarchical position within the party (Camerlo & Castaldo, 2024). Applied to the Argentine cabinet under Alberto Fernández, this approach reveals that apparently strong partisan cabinets may actually consist of ministers with limited organizational leverage over their parties (Camerlo et al., 2024). Ministers sharing the same partisan label therefore possess very different capacities to withstand political pressure.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial duration is shaped by who ministers are. Technical expertise, organizational embeddedness, political experience, and personal resources all influence survival prospects. Yet the effects of these traits depend fundamentally on the environments in which ministers operate. The same characteristic may be rewarded in one institutional setting and penalized in another. This observation leads naturally to the second major family of explanations.

1.2 Context-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Context-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the political environment rather than characteristics of individual ministers. Ministers survive or fail because of the institutional and political constraints surrounding them.

The comparative literature consistently identifies coalition dynamics as a central determinant of ministerial duration. Coalition type, minority government status, electoral volatility, and party-system fragmentation all shape the likelihood of ministerial replacement independently of individual characteristics (Huber & Martinez-Gallardo, 2008). Similarly, political crises, scandals, protests, electoral calendars, and term limits alter the incentives presidents face when deciding whether to retain or dismiss ministers (Alexiadou & Gunaydin, 2019; Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán, 2015). Even macroeconomic performance influences survival probabilities by modifying the

broader political environment within which governments operate (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

The case literature illustrates these mechanisms particularly clearly. For Colombia, Mejía Guinand et al. find that although individual characteristics matter, the institutional configuration of the political system ultimately determines the range within which those characteristics can operate (Mejía et al., 2021). Constitutional reforms, changes in party-system structure, and coalition arrangements alter the political logic governing ministerial careers. Similar conclusions emerge from Chile, where Avendaño and Dávila show that ministerial turnover during the Concertación governments was driven primarily by coalition management rather than by individual performance. Finance ministers consistently exhibited the longest tenures regardless of their personal characteristics (Avendaño & Dávila, 2012).

Recent work has also refined the contextual analysis of ministerial portfolios. Portfolio importance has traditionally been measured through expert rankings that assign ministries a single level of salience. Camerlo and Martínez-Gallardo argue that such measures obscure important differences among ministries, particularly in contexts characterized by weak party institutionalization (Camerlo & Gallardo, 2022). Their framework decomposes ministerial value into policy-management capacity, discretionary resource allocation, political agenda influence, and inter-portfolio coordination authority. Different political environments activate different dimensions of portfolio value, producing distinct survival incentives for presidents and ministers alike.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial survival depends not only on who ministers are but also on where they operate. Institutional structures, coalition arrangements, political crises, economic conditions, and portfolio characteristics jointly define the opportunities and constraints governing ministerial careers.

1.3 Reinterpreting Ministerial Continuity

The two families of explanations are not competing research programs. Virtually every empirical study combines individual and contextual covariates, with political environments conditioning the effects of ministerial characteristics. Together, these studies provide a rich understanding of why some ministers survive longer than others.

Despite their differences, however, they share an implicit assumption: ministerial duration is itself the phenomenon to be explained. Consequently, continuity is interpreted primarily as the outcome of cabinet management, coalition bargaining, institutional constraints, or individual characteristics. This common orientation leaves unexplored a different analytical possibility. Rather than asking why ministers remain in office, ministerial continuity may be interpreted as observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which governments preserve accumulated knowledge and develop institutional learning.

This paper adopts that alternative perspective. Ministerial continuity is not treated as evidence of organizational learning itself, nor does it imply that knowledge resides in individual ministers. Rather, continuity provides the organizational condition under which knowledge embedded in routines, procedures, institutional memory, and accumulated administrative experience can be preserved, transmitted, and refined over time despite inevitable personnel turnover. Organizations, not individuals, are therefore the principal unit through which knowledge accumulates.

This reinterpretation shifts the analytical focus from explaining individual ministerial survival to understanding the organizational conditions that make institutional learning possible. Instead of treating ministerial duration as a dependent variable, the paper treats patterns of continuity as empirical evidence about the capacity of political organizations to preserve and accumulate knowledge across successive governments.

The next section develops a deductive theoretical framework organized around two axioms and three propositions. The first axiom establishes organizational continuity as the necessary condition for organizational knowledge accumulation. The second identifies organizational knowledge accumulation as the necessary condition for institutional learning. Building upon these foundations, the propositions explain why continuity varies across political frameworks, how political frameworks generate different configurations of organizational protection, and why those protective arrangements produce differentiated continuity across ministerial portfolios. Together, these axioms and propositions provide the conceptual foundation for interpreting ministerial continuity as observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation and institutional learning become possible.

2 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework developed in this paper follows an axiomatic–deductive strategy. Rather than beginning with hypotheses to be statistically tested, it begins by specifying a set of latent organizational constructs together with the fundamental relationships that connect them. These relationships are expressed as axioms. They are not empirical hypotheses and therefore are not themselves subjected to statistical testing. Instead, they establish the theoretical ontology from which observable implications are deductively derived.

The observable implications of the theory are formulated as propositions. Unlike the axioms, the propositions are expressed exclusively in terms of observable historical quantities. Their role is to translate the latent theoretical relationships into empirical expectations that may be examined using historical evidence. Consequently, the empirical analyses developed later do not test the axioms directly. Rather, they evaluate whether the observable implications implied by the propositions are approximated by Peru’s historical trajectory.

This distinction is fundamental for the methodological strategy adopted throughout the paper. Definitions establish the meaning of the theoretical constructs.

Axioms specify the fundamental relationships among those latent constructs. Propositions translate those relationships into observable historical implications. Statistical analyses therefore evaluate observable duration patterns, while the axioms provide the theoretical interpretation of those patterns. In this sense, the statistical analyses neither verify nor falsify the axioms themselves; instead, they assess the extent to which the empirical record is consistent with the observable implications derived from the deductive framework.

Throughout the discussion, arrows ($\rightarrow$) denote deductive theoretical relationships rather than estimated causal effects. Unless explicitly stated otherwise, they should be interpreted as expressing enabling or necessary relationships among the constructs composing the theoretical framework.

2.1 Definitions

Organizational continuity (C) refers to the persistence of organizational processes through time despite the inevitable turnover of individual officeholders. Continuity concerns the preservation of organizational routines, procedures, institutional memory, and administrative practices rather than the permanence of particular individuals in office.

Organizational knowledge accumulation (K) refers to the process through which experience becomes progressively embedded in organizational routines, procedures, and institutional memory. Organizational knowledge is therefore understood as an organizational property rather than as an attribute of individual officeholders.

Institutional learning (IL) refers to the capacity of political institutions to improve governing practices by incorporating accumulated organizational knowledge into future institutional arrangements. Institutional learning is therefore conceived as an institutional property emerging from organizational processes rather than from the experiences of individual political actors.

Protective belts (PB) refer to latent organizational arrangements that preserve organizational continuity by increasing the political or administrative costs associated with disrupting organizational routines. Protective belts protect organizational continuity rather than individual officeholders.

Political Frameworks (PF) refer to historically bounded institutional environments produced by completed Critical Junctures. Political Frameworks constitute the observable historical contexts within which governmental organizations operate.

2.2 Axiom A1: Organizational Continuity Enables Organizational Knowledge Accumulation

The first axiom establishes the organizational foundation of the theoretical framework. Organizations are temporal entities. Unlike isolated political decisions, organizational processes unfold through repeated interaction, the preservation of routines, and the retention of institutional memory. Consequently, organizational knowledge cannot accumulate independently of some degree of organizational continuity.

The first axiom is stated as

$$C \rightarrow K \tag{A1}$$

where C denotes organizational continuity and K denotes organizational knowledge accumulation.

Axiom A1 should be interpreted as expressing an enabling organizational relationship rather than a deterministic causal claim. Organizational continuity makes knowledge accumulation possible by allowing experience to be retained, articulated, transmitted, and progressively incorporated into organizational routines. It does not imply that organizations necessarily learn, innovate, or improve. The axiom identifies continuity as a necessary organizational condition for knowledge accumulation, not as a sufficient condition for organizational success.

Although introduced here as a foundational premise, Axiom A1 is broadly compatible with several established research traditions. Organizational learning theory emphasizes that knowledge emerges cumulatively through repeated interaction, articulation, retention, and routinization (Levitt & March, 1988; Nonaka, 1998). Conversely, the notion of *organized anarchy* highlights how fluid participation disrupts the organizational continuity required for shared learning and stable organizational memory (Cohen et al., 1972). Public policy theory reinforces the same principle by emphasizing that complex decision-making depends upon sequential problem structuring, incremental refinement, routines, and standard operating procedures (Allison, 1969; Foss & Foss, 2005; Lindblom, 1959).

Taken together, these literatures converge on a common organizational premise: organizations preserve knowledge through continuity. Axiom A1 adopts this premise as the first deductive foundation of the framework.

2.3 Axiom A2: Organizational Knowledge Accumulation Enables Institutional Learning

Axiom A1 established the organizational condition under which knowledge may accumulate. A second and conceptually distinct question concerns the institutional consequences of accumulated organizational knowledge. Under what conditions can political institutions themselves be said to learn?

The second axiom is stated as

$$K \rightarrow IL \quad (A2)$$

where K denotes organizational knowledge accumulation and IL denotes institutional learning.

Axiom A2 should be interpreted as expressing an enabling institutional relationship rather than a deterministic causal claim. Accumulated organizational knowledge provides the experiential foundation upon which institutional learning may occur, but it does not guarantee that political institutions will adapt successfully or improve their governing capacity. Political institutions may preserve substantial organizational knowledge while continuing to reproduce ineffective routines, maladaptive organizational arrangements, or unsuccessful policy choices. The axiom therefore identifies organizational knowledge accumulation as a necessary precondition for institutional learning, not as a sufficient condition for institutional improvement.

This premise is broadly compatible with organizational and policy learning literatures. Fiol and Lyles distinguish between accumulated experience and learning, emphasizing that learning requires shared understandings capable of influencing future organizational action (Fiol & Lyles, 1985). Olsen extends this logic to political institutions by treating constitutions, administrative routines, laws, and organizational practices as repositories of accumulated knowledge through which institutions interpret experience and adapt over time (Olsen, 2010). Similarly, Hall's account of policy learning emphasizes that governments revise policy goals, instruments, and governing practices on the basis of accumulated experience rather than isolated political responses (Hall, 1993).

Axiom A2 therefore locates institutional learning at a higher analytical level than organizational knowledge accumulation. Knowledge remains an organizational property; institutional learning is an institutional property that may emerge when accumulated organizational knowledge is preserved, interpreted, and incorporated into future governing practices.

2.4 Axiom A3: Protective Belts Preserve Organizational Continuity

Axioms A1 and A2 established that organizational continuity enables organizational knowledge accumulation and that accumulated organizational knowledge enables institutional learning. A third question naturally follows. If organizational continuity is repeatedly exposed to political turnover, under what conditions can it be preserved?

The third axiom is stated as

$$PB \rightarrow C \quad (A3)$$

where PB denotes the strength of a Protective Belt and C denotes organizational continuity.

Axiom A3 expresses an enabling organizational relationship rather than a deterministic causal claim. Protective Belts increase the likelihood that organizational continuity will be preserved by raising the political, institutional, administrative, or societal costs associated with organizational disruption. They do not guarantee continuity, nor do they protect individual officeholders. Political leaders remain free to appoint and dismiss ministers whenever political circumstances require. Rather, the axiom states that organizations surrounded by stronger Protective Belts are more likely to preserve the organizational conditions under which routines, institutional memory, procedures, and accumulated knowledge can persist despite recurrent political turnover.

Although introduced here as an axiomatic premise, the organizational logic underlying Protective Belts draws upon several complementary theoretical traditions. Organizational sociology emphasizes that complex organizations develop stable systems of regulation, interdependence, and collective action that reduce arbitrary organizational disruption (**crozier_regulation_1976**). Historical institutionalism explains how institutional arrangements generate increasing costs of reversal as organizational capabilities, coordination, learning, and stakeholder expectations accumulate over time (**pierson_increasing_2000**). Bureaucratic politics further shows that governmental organizations may acquire reputational capital and broad external support that make political intervention increasingly costly, thereby generating forms of bureaucratic autonomy extending beyond formal legal protections (**carpenter_forging_2020**). Finally, institutional theories of political decision-making demonstrate that political actors rarely exercise unconstrained discretion. Instead, institutional configurations impose differential political costs on organizational and policy change, making some forms of intervention substantially more difficult than others (**tsebelis_decision_1995**).

Importantly, none of these traditions independently explains the emergence of Protective Belts. Rather, each identifies a distinct mechanism through which organizational disruption becomes increasingly costly. Organizational regulation generates internal stability; increasing returns make accumulated organizational capabilities progressively more valuable; bureaucratic reputation creates external political support; and institutional constraints limit discretionary political intervention. The concept of the Protective Belt synthesizes these complementary mechanisms into a single latent construct representing the aggregate protection surrounding a governmental organization. Consequently, Protective Belts are not directly observed but inferred from systematic differences in organizational continuity across otherwise comparable governmental organizations.

Evidence consistent with this organizational logic appears in comparative studies of ministerial survival. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that foreign affairs portfolios exhibit substantially longer ministerial survival than most domestic portfolios across Latin America. They argue that foreign ministers become accountable not only to domestic political actors but also to international audiences, thereby in-

creasing the political costs associated with ministerial replacement (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Their findings illustrate how broader political constraints may be translated into differentiated organizational protection.

Together, Axioms A1–A3 define the latent organizational structure of the theoretical framework,

$$PB \rightarrow C \rightarrow K \rightarrow IL.$$

The three axioms are not intended to explain historical variation. Rather, they specify the organizational conditions under which institutional learning becomes possible. The propositions that follow translate this latent organizational structure into observable implications expressed exclusively in terms of Political Frameworks, governmental organizations, and ministerial duration.

2.5 From Latent Theory to Observable Propositions

The three axioms establish relationships among latent organizational constructs and are therefore not directly testable. Empirical evaluation requires translating those latent relationships into observable implications. Throughout this paper, Political Frameworks and governmental organizations constitute observable historical entities, while ministerial duration serves as an observable indicator of organizational continuity. Consequently, the propositions that follow are expressed exclusively in terms of observable quantities. Their theoretical interpretation is subsequently derived from Axioms A1–A3.

2.5.1 *Proposition 1: Political Frameworks and Institutional Learning*

The first proposition concerns historical variation across Political Frameworks. The Political Frameworks employed throughout this study are not derived from the ministerial data analyzed here. Rather, they constitute the empirical operationalization of an independent comparative-historical reconstruction of Peru’s political development presented in the previous section. Consequently, the empirical analysis does not search inductively for historical breakpoints. Instead, it evaluates whether ministerial duration patterns are consistent with historically identified institutional transformations.

The first proposition is stated as

$$PF \rightarrow D \tag{P1}$$

where PF denotes Political Frameworks and D denotes ministerial duration.

Observable implication. Successive Political Frameworks are expected to exhibit progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration.

Theoretical implication. If the observed historical trajectory exhibits progressively longer ministerial duration across successive Political Frameworks, Axioms A1 and A2 imply that the organizational conditions for organizational knowledge accumulation and, consequently, institutional learning have become increasingly favorable over historical time. Conversely, the absence of progressively longer duration patterns would indicate that the empirical record provides no evidence that successive Political Frameworks generated increasingly favorable conditions for institutional learning.

2.5.2 *Proposition 2: Protective Belts Within Political Frameworks*

The second proposition concerns organizational variation within Political Frameworks. Whereas Proposition P1 examines historical differences across institutional environments, Proposition 2 examines whether organizations operating under the same Political Framework exhibit systematically different patterns of organizational continuity.

The principal comparison concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). As argued in the previous section, the selective reconstruction of the Peruvian state following the reforms of the 1990s provides strong theoretical reasons to expect that macroeconomic governance became surrounded by stronger organizational protection than governmental organizations primarily responsible for political coordination. Additional ministerial portfolios are incorporated as organizational benchmarks and robustness checks.

The second proposition is therefore stated as

$$(PF, Portfolio) \rightarrow D \quad (P2)$$

where PF denotes Political Frameworks, $Portfolio$ denotes governmental organizations, and D denotes ministerial duration.

Observable implication. Within the same Political Framework, ministerial duration is expected to differ systematically across governmental organizations.

Theoretical implication. According to Axiom A3, systematic differences in ministerial duration across organizations operating under the same Political Framework are interpreted as evidence consistent with differential Protective Belts. Organizations exhibiting greater ministerial continuity are inferred to possess stronger Protective Belts because the political, institutional, administrative, and societal costs associated with organizational disruption are comparatively higher. The empirical analyses therefore evaluate whether the historical record exhibits the organizational continuity patterns expected under the proposed theory of Protective Belts.

2.6 Governmental Organizations and Executive Agency

The theoretical framework developed thus far identifies Political Frameworks as the principal historical environments within which organizational continuity is

generated, preserved, or interrupted. The empirical application, however, requires distinguishing between the organizational units through which these theoretical mechanisms operate and the political actors who exercise executive authority within those environments.

The organizational units of the theory are governmental organizations, operationalized in this study as ministerial portfolios. Organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, and Protective Belts are therefore conceptualized as properties of governmental organizations rather than of individual ministers. Ministers occupy organizations temporarily, whereas organizations persist beyond successive officeholders. Consequently, the theoretical mechanisms developed in the preceding propositions operate at the organizational level.

Political Frameworks do not distribute organizational continuity directly. Rather, they generate configurations of Protective Belts surrounding different governmental organizations according to the strategic priorities embedded within each historical environment. Organizations operating under the same Political Framework may therefore experience systematically different opportunities for organizational continuity. Formally,

$$PF_i \longrightarrow PB_i^{(j)} \longrightarrow C_i^{(j)},$$

where governmental organization j denotes a particular ministerial portfolio.

Presidential administrations occupy a different analytical position within the framework. Presidents exercise executive authority within the institutional opportunities and constraints established by a Political Framework. They appoint ministers, dismiss cabinets, manage governing coalitions, and respond to political crises. Consequently, presidential administrations introduce an additional source of variation affecting ministerial continuity. This variation reflects executive agency operating within a Political Framework rather than an alternative historical environment.

Accordingly, each observed ministerial spell is simultaneously situated within three distinct contexts. First, it belongs to a governmental organization through which organizational continuity and knowledge accumulation occur. Second, it unfolds under a particular presidential administration exercising executive authority. Third, both organizations and presidents operate within a common Political Framework that defines the broader historical environment.

This distinction has direct methodological implications. Political Frameworks constitute the principal historical construct specified by the theory and are therefore modeled as fixed historical environments. Ministerial portfolios identify the governmental organizations through which the theoretical mechanisms operate and consequently enter the empirical analyses as organizational categories. Presidential administrations, by contrast, represent a source of shared executive-level heterogeneity because ministerial appointments and dismissals occur under presidential authority. Ministerial spells observed during the same presidential administration therefore cannot reasonably be assumed to be statistically independent. The empirical analyses

account for this dependence through shared frailty models while preserving the historical and organizational structure specified by the theoretical framework.

3 Peru as an Empirical Application

The theoretical framework developed in the previous section proposes a general explanation linking Political Frameworks, organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, and institutional learning. These concepts are not specific to Peru. Rather, they describe historical and organizational processes that could, in principle, operate in any political system. Peru is therefore introduced not because the theory was derived from the Peruvian experience, but because its republican history provides an unusually informative empirical application through which the observable implications of the framework can be examined.

The empirical value of Peru lies in the coexistence of two characteristics that rarely appear simultaneously. First, nearly two centuries of republican continuity encompass multiple episodes of profound institutional transformation, allowing the identification of successive Political Frameworks generated by completed Critical Junctions. Second, despite these repeated historical reconfigurations, the Peruvian executive has maintained a broadly comparable ministerial organization, permitting the study of organizational continuity under different historical environments while holding the basic organizational architecture of government relatively constant.

From the perspective adopted here, Peru therefore constitutes a natural historical laboratory. Rather than assuming that institutional reforms necessarily improve governance or generate cumulative political progress, the theoretical framework proposes that successive Political Frameworks create different organizational conditions under which governmental knowledge may accumulate. Whether these conditions became progressively more favorable over time remains an empirical question rather than a theoretical assumption. The Peruvian experience is particularly well suited to examining this question because its historical trajectory includes multiple completed Political Frameworks whose organizational consequences can be compared systematically.

This section operationalizes the principal historical and organizational concepts introduced in the theoretical framework. It first presents the Political Frameworks derived from Peru's completed Critical Junctions, thereby operationalizing Proposition ???. It then examines the selective organizational reconstruction associated with the post-1990 political settlement, providing the historical motivation for Proposition ???. Finally, it explains why the ministerial portfolios selected for analysis constitute theoretically informative organizational comparisons through which the observable implications of Proposition ??? may be evaluated.

3.1 Political Frameworks and Critical Junctures

Proposition ?? argues that Political Frameworks generate the historical environments within which organizational continuity becomes more or less likely. Because Political Frameworks are latent historical constructs rather than directly observable entities, they require empirical operationalization before their observable implications can be examined.

This study operationalizes Political Frameworks using the comparative-historical tradition of Critical Junctures, which conceives political development as a succession of relatively stable institutional environments separated by comparatively brief episodes of profound institutional transformation. Critical Junctures reorganize political authority, redefine governing coalitions, and establish durable institutional legacies that subsequently structure political life over extended periods of time (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007; Collier & Munck, 2022). Consistent with the theoretical framework developed in the previous section, the Critical Junctures themselves are not the object of analysis. Rather, they constitute the historical processes through which new Political Frameworks emerge. The empirical analyses therefore focus on the relatively stable historical environments generated by completed Critical Junctures.

Following the historical reconstruction developed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025), Peru's republican history is organized into six successive Political Frameworks bounded by five completed Critical Junctures and a sixth Political Framework associated with an ongoing Critical Juncture. Because the current political realignment remains unresolved, the institutional legacy of the most recent framework should be regarded as provisional.

Table ?? presents the Political Frameworks employed throughout the empirical analyses. These frameworks constitute the empirical operationalization of Proposition ?? and provide the historical environments within which organizational continuity is subsequently evaluated.

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Although each Critical Juncture emerged from distinct historical circumstances, they share an important organizational characteristic. Rather than merely replacing governments or constitutions, each fundamentally reconfigured the organizational architecture of the Peruvian state by altering governing priorities, administrative capacities, and the distribution of political authority.

The War of the Pacific exposed the absence of a coherent national state capable of coordinating military, fiscal, and administrative resources, initiating a prolonged period of state reconstruction under oligarchic leadership. The collapse of the Aristocratic Republic transformed an exclusionary political order into one increasingly confronted by mass political mobilization and organized social actors. The Military Revolution radically expanded state organizational capacity through agrarian reform,

nationalization, and the creation of new public institutions while simultaneously restricting democratic competition. The combined crises of terrorism, hyperinflation, and institutional collapse during the 1980s culminated in the constitutional settlement of the 1990s, which selectively reorganized the Peruvian state around macroeconomic stabilization and market governance. Finally, the contemporary political crisis initiated after the removal of President Pedro Castillo suggests that the post-1993 settlement may itself be entering a new period of institutional reconfiguration whose long-term legacy remains uncertain.

From the perspective of the present framework, the substantive importance of these transformations lies not primarily in constitutional or electoral change, but in their consequences for the organizational environment within which governmental organizations operate. Each Political Framework established a distinct configuration of governing priorities, institutional capacities, and political incentives, thereby creating different conditions under which organizational continuity and, consequently, organizational knowledge accumulation could emerge.

Accordingly, the Political Frameworks summarized in Table ?? provide the historical operationalization of Proposition ?. They define the successive historical environments within which the observable implications of the deductive framework are evaluated throughout the remainder of the paper.

3.2 The Selective Organizational Reconstruction of the State

The previous subsection operationalized Political Frameworks as the historical environments within which organizational continuity is expected to vary. Proposition ?, however, concerns a different question. If Political Frameworks allocate organizational protection unevenly across governmental organizations, where should such protective arrangements be expected to emerge? The transition to the fifth Political Framework provides a particularly informative setting for addressing this question.

Although the fifth Political Framework is treated as a single historical environment throughout the analyses, the institutional reforms initiated during the 1990s deserve particular attention because they selectively transformed some governmental organizations more profoundly than others. Rather than redefining the Political Framework itself, these reforms altered the internal organizational architecture through which the Peruvian state pursued macroeconomic governance. They therefore provide the principal historical motivation for the organizational comparison developed in this study.

Peru's renewed integration into international markets after the crises of the 1980s did not constitute the country's first experience with outward-oriented development. Throughout both the colonial and republican periods, successive governments repeatedly adopted development strategies centered on primary exports, liberal economic policies, and close integration with the dominant international economy of their time. What distinguished the post-1990 reforms was therefore not the adoption of

market-oriented policies themselves, but the organizational response through which those policies were implemented.

The combined crises of terrorism, hyperinflation, fiscal collapse, external indebtedness, and the breakdown of the traditional party system created an exceptional opportunity for institutional redesign. Rather than simply reducing the role of the state through privatization and deregulation, the reforms simultaneously strengthened a relatively small set of governmental organizations responsible for macroeconomic governance. Fiscal authority became increasingly centralized within the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF); budgetary institutions were modernized; tax administration was reinforced; monetary autonomy was consolidated; and progressively more formalized fiscal rules, planning procedures, and administrative routines were introduced. The reforms therefore represented not merely a shift in economic policy, but a selective reconstruction of the organizational architecture of the Peruvian state.

The subsequent commodity boom reinforced these organizational changes. Sustained economic growth, expanding exports, and increasing foreign investment provided both the fiscal resources and the political legitimacy necessary for the new institutional arrangements to persist across successive governments. At the same time, continued integration into global markets made credible macroeconomic management increasingly indispensable. Consequently, the organizational knowledge embedded within institutions responsible for fiscal policy, debt management, public investment, and macroeconomic programming became progressively more valuable to the functioning of the state.

From the perspective developed in this paper, these historical developments do not demonstrate the existence of Protective Belts. Rather, they identify the historical conditions under which such protective arrangements could plausibly emerge. Proposition ?? argues that Political Frameworks allocate organizational protection selectively according to their governing priorities. If the post-1990 organizational settlement concentrated technical expertise, institutional memory, and administrative capacity within macroeconomic institutions, then organizations responsible for preserving those capabilities should have become increasingly costly to disrupt.

This interpretation also motivates an additional empirical consideration. Although the fifth Political Framework begins with the constitutional settlement of 1993, many of the organizational reforms discussed above unfolded progressively throughout the 1990s. Consequently, the empirical analyses later examine not only differences across Political Frameworks but also the robustness of the principal findings before and after the consolidation of the post-1990 organizational settlement.

The observable implication follows directly. If the selective organizational reconstruction of the state concentrated valuable organizational knowledge within macroeconomic institutions, organizations responsible for macroeconomic governance should exhibit greater organizational continuity than organizations whose principal function remains political coordination or the management of recurrent political crises. The following subsection explains why the comparison between the Ministry of Econ-

omy and Finance and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers provides the principal organizational contrast through which this expectation is evaluated.

3.3 Governmental Organizations as Analytical Units

The theoretical framework developed in this paper concerns governmental organizations rather than the careers of individual ministers. Organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, and Protective Belts are therefore conceptualized as properties of governmental organizations, empirically operationalized here through ministerial portfolios. Ministers temporarily occupy these organizations, whereas the organizations themselves persist across successive presidential administrations and Political Frameworks. Consequently, the empirical analyses compare organizations rather than individuals.

The empirical application distinguishes three analytically distinct contexts within which every ministerial spell is observed. First, each spell belongs to a governmental organization, operationalized as a ministerial portfolio. This constitutes the organizational unit through which continuity, accumulated organizational knowledge, and Protective Belts are conceptualized. Second, every spell occurs under a particular presidential administration, representing the executive context responsible for ministerial appointments, cabinet formation, and ministerial replacement. Third, both governmental organizations and presidential administrations operate within a Political Framework, which provides the broader historical environment introduced in Proposition ??.

These three contexts should not be interpreted as forming a simple hierarchy. Governmental organizations persist across successive presidential administrations and Political Frameworks, whereas each presidential administration simultaneously governs multiple governmental organizations. Ministerial spells therefore emerge from the intersection of historical, organizational, and executive contexts rather than from a single nested structure. Throughout the empirical analyses, Political Frameworks represent historical environments, governmental organizations constitute the organizational units through which the theoretical mechanisms operate, and presidential administrations capture executive-level heterogeneity affecting observed ministerial continuity.

The principal organizational comparison concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). Both occupy central positions within the executive branch, yet they perform fundamentally different organizational functions. The comparison is theoretically informative because both organizations participate continuously in cabinet government while facing markedly different organizational incentives. Their principal difference lies not in institutional rank but in organizational function. Whereas the PCM coordinates political coalitions under conditions of continual political conflict, the MEF manages specialized governmental capabilities whose effectiveness depends heavily upon technical credibility, procedural stability, standardized administrative routines, and

accumulated organizational knowledge. This combination of comparable institutional position and contrasting organizational function provides a particularly informative setting for evaluating the observable implications of Propositions ?? and ??.

The PCM functions as the executive's principal organization for political coordination. It articulates cabinet action, negotiates with Congress, manages inter-ministerial conflicts, and preserves the political viability of the executive. Because it operates at the intersection of governmental coordination and political conflict, it is also the organization most directly exposed to recurrent political crises. Cabinet reshuffles, legislative confrontations, presidential scandals, and episodes of social unrest frequently culminate in the replacement of the Prime Minister without fundamentally altering the broader organizational structure of government. In organizational terms, the PCM functions as the executive's principal political shock absorber, absorbing political instability through leadership turnover while preserving governmental operation.

The organizational role of the MEF is fundamentally different. Rather than coordinating political coalitions, it coordinates macroeconomic governance. As discussed in the previous subsection, the organizational reconstruction initiated during the 1990s progressively concentrated fiscal authority, budgetary management, debt administration, macroeconomic programming, and public investment within the MEF. These responsibilities depend upon specialized technical expertise, institutional memory, standardized administrative procedures, and accumulated organizational routines developed over time. Unlike political coordination, whose priorities may legitimately change in response to changing political circumstances, macroeconomic governance derives much of its effectiveness from organizational continuity and long-term policy credibility.

The argument is therefore organizational rather than political. The claim is not that the MEF became insulated from democratic accountability or immune to ministerial replacement. Ministers continued to be appointed and dismissed by elected governments, and macroeconomic policy remained politically contestable. Rather, if the post-1990 organizational settlement selectively strengthened macroeconomic governance, then the organizational knowledge embedded within the MEF became progressively more valuable and therefore increasingly costly to disrupt. From the perspective of the present theoretical framework, the MEF consequently represents the governmental organization in which a Protective Belt is most plausibly expected to emerge.

Three additional governmental organizations are incorporated for two complementary reasons. First, they broaden the organizational scope of the empirical analysis by allowing the principal comparison between the MEF and the PCM to be evaluated against organizations performing substantially different governmental functions. Second, they increase the amount of survival information available for empirical analysis, thereby permitting robustness analyses under alternative historical partitions and reducing the possibility that the principal findings reflect limited

statistical power rather than theoretically meaningful organizational differences.

The Ministry of the Interior represents the state's coercive and internal security functions, whose organizational continuity has historically been shaped by terrorism, crime, police reform, and public order. The Ministries of Health and Education represent two of the state's largest providers of public services and address policy domains requiring sustained administrative capacity and long-term organizational development. Although these organizations also depend upon accumulated organizational knowledge, they were not selectively reconstructed during the post-1990 organizational settlement in the same manner as macroeconomic governance.

Together, these five governmental organizations represent contrasting organizational functions rather than merely different policy sectors. The PCM represents political coordination under conditions of continual political exposure. The MEF represents specialized macroeconomic governance under conditions requiring organizational continuity and technical credibility. Interior, Health, and Education provide organizational reference points operating under different administrative and political incentives. This configuration allows the empirical analyses to evaluate whether organizational continuity varies systematically in ways consistent with the observable implications derived from the theoretical framework.

The empirical analyses do not seek to demonstrate that one governmental organization is inherently superior to another, nor that longer ministerial tenure necessarily produces more effective public policy. Rather, they examine whether Peru's historical trajectory exhibits patterns of organizational continuity consistent with the observable implications derived from the deductive framework. Because organizational knowledge accumulation and institutional learning remain latent theoretical constructs, the analyses rely on ministerial continuity as an observable proxy for the organizational conditions under which knowledge may accumulate. The following section translates these theoretical expectations into an empirical research design.

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